Involving employees

Creativity comes as standard equipment with everyone who works in your organization. To paraphrase one manager, with every pair of hands there comes a free brain. The challenge lies in engaging this creativity—or how to tap into this resource to keep making innovation happen.

Involving over the long term

***CI**—*continuous improvement: a steady stream of incremental innovation. One of the most powerful engines for change in organizations is mobilizing the efforts of employees to deliver this.*

An organization can choose to involve all employees in innovation (high involvement) or only a few (low involvement). The extent of involvement depends in part on whether the planned innovations are radical (high impact) or incremental (low impact). Either way, employees must feel motivated, empowered, and enabled to contribute if they are to help in innovation.

Once you have started the innovation process, the difficulty lies in keeping it going long enough to make a real difference. Many organizations start the process, have an initial surge of ideas and enthusiasm, and then see it gradually ebb away until there is little or no CI* activity. This isn't surprising—to change the way people think and behave on a long-term basis requires a strategic development program.

IN FOCUS... HIGH-INVOLVEMENT INNOVATION

High-involvement innovation has been around for a while. Denny's Shipyard in Dumbarton, Scotland, back in 1871 asked—and rewarded—workers for "any change by which work is rendered superior in quality or more economical in cost." It makes a big difference to firms like Toyota that do this on a systematic basis—it receives around two million suggestions a year from its workforce (Kawasaki Engineering, another high-involvement player, has a staggering seven million)—and it implements the majority of these.